Despite his misfortune, Assad expressed gratitude for the GDR's support and awarded a contract for the construction of a giant cement factory near Tartus on the Mediterranean coast to an East German concern. Although the factory thrived, it was a poorly evaluated project and created an environmental disaster polluting a long stretch of pristine coastline and destroying thousands of olive trees.

That autumn, the tension and violence in the Middle East was matched decibel for decibel by events in South America, where a military coup d'état deposed the Popular Unity government of President Salvador Allende. Led by General Augusto Pinochet, the rebellion not only seized power but ended in the dramatic suicide of Allende, who shot himself with an AK-47 assault rifle. 'The working people of the German Democratic Republic learned of the outrageous fact that a military coup against the constitutional government of Unidad Popular and the elected President Salvador Allende has been unleashed in Chile,' Neues Deutschland raged. The brutal crackdown by the military, backed by the CIA, and Allende's suicide caused a worldwide sensation. During a session of the central committee, Honecker paid tribute to the life and work of Allende saying he was faithful to his people and their struggle for freedom and independence, for democracy and social justice. 'Our party will always, hold in high esteem his memory and the memory of the murdered communists and socialists of Chile, of all those who have given their lives to the cause of the people.'6

Offering further proof of their anger, thousands of East Germans took part in rallies in Dresden, Rostock, Leipzig and Halle in what Neue Zeit described as a 'genuine declaration of solidarity between the GDR and its brother Chilean people'. Henceforward, at Honecker's urging, the Politburo granted asylum to Chilean communists fearing for their lives, a move which led to about 2,000 refugees relocating to East Germany.

Remarkably, their integration was a largely un-bureaucratic affair. Chileans were aided by the Free German Trade Union Confederation (FDGB) and the 'Solidarity Committee of the GDR' which provided funds to finance accommodation and clothing. Each emigrant family received a transitional allowance of DDM2,500 to bridge the time until a job was found. (Stasi